

THE COLLEGE APPLICATION ESSAY

Who's reading your essay, and what do they want?

- 1) What's the goal here? The hope of the admissions officers who read your application is that they will get to know you well through your application. Whether or not you are ultimately admitted, they want to understand just who it is they are considering. Your essay is a big part of that.
- 2) Does anyone even read it? The answer is YES. Colleges that require an essay do so for a reason. If they weren't going to read it, they wouldn't bother asking for it.
- 3) The essay is only one part of the whole application, but it is the most personal part. Courses, grades and test scores are important but lack personality. School recommendations are written by other people. The essay is all about what you choose to convey to the admissions committee about yourself.
- 4) What's more important, grammar and style, or content? They are equally important. Admissions officers hope to learn a number of things from your essay:

How well do you write? If the writing is articulate, you've probably done well in English and will be off to a good start in college. If it is problematic in spots, how small or large are the problems? Can the admissions committee overlook them? Would you need some writing help if admitted, and if so, is the college able to provide that help?

What do you have to say? Is the essay reflective and personal? Does it get at the heart of what you are trying to convey? A page packed with text doesn't necessarily mean you have more to say than someone of fewer words. Sometimes, less is more. One student might convey why they love music more convincingly in a short essay than the student who writes about it in a long but superficial piece. On the other hand, sometimes you do need more words to tell your story.

Does the voice in the essay sound genuine? The best college essays will have the voice of the person who wrote them—usually, a 17(ish)-year-old high school student who comes to life on paper through their words. An essay that has been overly-edited by the adults in your life will lose that voice. (Lesson: write it yourself.)

- 5) What does an admissions officer 'get' from reading your essay? Many, many things, among which might be:
- A better understanding of your background, which can help put the rest of the application in context.
 - An understanding of why certain experiences or people have been so important to you, and thus something about what you value.
 - A sense of an intellectual bent, a playful mind, or a sense of humor.
 - A sense of your commitment to the things that most interest you and of how those interests developed.
 - A sense of the way you interact with others and/or are perceived by them.
 - An understanding of a special talent you would bring to the college or a special quality you might add to a residential community.
 - And again, hopefully a good, and realistic, sense of the flesh-and-blood person behind the words.
- 6) Is it ok to write on a controversial subject? If it's something you feel passionate about, go ahead. But write about the topic as it affects you, not simply as something that is a challenging issue in the world today. Remember, it's a 'personal' essay through which we are trying to get to know you.
- 7) If your essay is great, will it get you in? Or if it isn't great, will it keep you out? It depends on what the rest of the application is like. In an otherwise very strong application, a just-average essay won't keep you from being admitted. Nor will a great essay make up for clear deficiencies elsewhere in the application. But if the rest of the application makes you look like a solid candidate at a particular college, a good personal statement can help tip the scale in your favor.
- 8) What if the essay you've written is a lot longer than the word limit suggested? Edit it. You do not want to annoy the people who read your application. If a college asks you for a one-page essay, don't send three pages. And don't fit it onto one page by shrinking it into tiny type on your word processor. People have to be able to read it.

Colleges ask you to limit the length for good reason. The admissions office may have thousands of applications to read; if 15,000 or 20,000 applicants write 'just one more page', that's a lot of extra verbiage for admissions staff to process. Forcing you to be selective also gives us a better sense of what's most important to you. It's easy to run on until you've said everything you have to say; it's harder to limit yourself, but you will end up selecting the most important details. That being said, if the story you need to tell is important and truly cannot be told within the word limit suggested (and you think the admissions office would agree), be as concise as possible but write the essay. It will be read.

Note: beginning in 2013-14 the Common Application will enforce word limits on its essay, a minimum of 250 words and a maximum of 650. You will be unable to submit more than that.

Writing your essay: some thoughts and tips

TO BEGIN WITH...

- 1) Remember that this is the part of the application you have total control over. (That's good.)
- 2) Don't write your essay at the last minute. This is an important part of the application. Leave yourself enough time to be able to think about it for awhile, talk about it with others if you want, write it, leave it for a few days, and come back to it.
- 3) Take seriously any specific instructions an admissions office might include (length, topic, etc.)
- 4) If you have questions, don't be afraid to call the admissions office. They're used to getting calls like yours.

FOCUSING YOUR THOUGHTS and CHOOSING A TOPIC

- 1) Read all of the essay questions asked by all of the colleges you are applying to. Do all of your schools use the Common Application? If so, you can write one essay. Do they all ask for second essays? If you can write one that is appropriate for three colleges, all the better. Two schools may have open-ended topics, one may be more focused, and if you gear your essay toward the more focused topic you may be able to/want to use it for all three schools. Then...
- 2) Sit around and THINK for awhile. What is this essay question asking? Does it speak to me? Make sure your essay answers it, but tell your own story. If the question gives you some latitude, mull over various ideas until you hit upon one that "feels" right, or about which you're more excited than others. If you've stared at your computer screen for an hour and a half and written two lines, you don't have the right topic. Quit for today. Come back tomorrow and start again. If you have the right topic, you'll know it because the writing will flow more easily.
- 3) An interesting topic does not automatically mean an interesting essay. Similarly: an ordinary topic does not automatically mean an ordinary essay.
- 4) Write about something that is important to YOU (not to your brother, mother, counselor, or any of the other people who are giving you advice). It will be easier to write and will have a more natural voice.
- 5) Don't try to second-guess the admissions office. Not "what do they want to hear?" or "what would they like?" but "what do I want to tell them? What do I want them to know about me before they make their decision? What should I talk about that will give them a feeling for what makes me tick?" Remember, you're in the driver's seat for this one.

WRITING

- 1) Don't try and cover too much. All-encompassing essays will either be too long or, if shorter, superficial. Think about the writing you have read and enjoyed: writing is usually interesting because of its detail, not its generalities.
- 2) Be personal. It's your application, your experiences, your thoughts, interests and personality. The admissions committee is trying to get to know you through your own words. Even if the topic is an intellectual one, the reader is looking for a personal response.
- 3) Convey your feelings. If you're excited about something, convey that. If you feel strongly about something (positive or negative), express that. Dry essays devoid of feeling don't tend to be very interesting.
- 4) Don't try to be something you aren't. If the humor feels self-conscious, forget it. Don't force a "creative" essay. Write in a voice which feels natural to you.
- 5) Be reflective. Write in some depth. Use some detail or specifics, not just general (and superficial, and easy) statements. Flesh out your thoughts. Ask yourself why and how a lot as you write, not so much what, when and where.
- 6) What you say as well as how you say it are both important. A great idea poorly expressed will not seem so great.

AFTER WRITING...

- 1) PROOFREAD PROOFREAD PROOFREAD. Neatness and accurate spelling and punctuation count.
- 2) Do not ask other people to revise your essay. Honesty also counts. It's YOUR essay. Someone else can read it and react to it, but they shouldn't be sitting at the keyboard as they do so.

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AND FINALLY...Once you've sent your application in, stop worrying about it. If you did your best, that's all you can ask of yourself.

Essay Writing Tips

General

Read and answer the question asked.

You'd be amazed how many essays we receive that don't relate at all to the question we were asking!

Be authentic.

We want to hear your voice in your response – the experiences, opinions and values that have shaped you. Feel free to write on something you are passionate about so we can get to know you better.

Be proactive!

Each year, we talk to students who have everything ready but their essays – if they could just get them finished, their application would be complete. Get started on your essays soon, and don't spend months agonizing over whether they're perfect. We don't read through them with a red pen in hand!

Avoid re-writing your accomplishments.

You've already given us that information in your application.

Re-use essays (or portions of essays) when possible.

However, make sure to re-read before hitting the submit button or mailing them in! The worst possible way to finish your essay to U-M is to say, "And I just can't wait to be a Spartan!" This happens. Seriously.

A research paper is different from an essay.

If you are re-using something you've previously written, make sure it directly answers our question and not one that a teacher posed to you for an assignment.

There is no "right" answer.

Don't think you know what we want to hear. Whatever you have to say about the topic is of interest to us.

English 101

Use mature professional writing skills.

Avoid contractions, slang, and "you." If you have questions, talk to your English teacher.

Avoid funny fonts, big margins, large font size, etc.

We were once in school too, and we know all the tricks for making things appear longer than they really are! Work with a standard font and size.

Explain any abbreviations.

Sure, we know the obvious ones (NHS), but talking about the B.O.B. award that you won for participating in the F.D.R. may not make sense to someone who doesn't go to your high school.

If making an argument, back it up with consistent facts.

Have an opinion about global warming? Affirmative action? Think that capital punishment is evil? Why? Your argument should be supported by facts, not the opinions of others.

Plagiarism is academic fraud and will cause your application to be thrown out of consideration.

You know those great websites that will write your essays for you? We know about them too. Aah, the power of Google...

Pick one topic and stay with it.

You don't have a lot of room to discuss a variety of different topics, so strive for depth on one subject versus breadth.

Use spell-check and proofread your essay.

Look at this slightly different (from actual essays) spelling of a, um, common word – that spell-check wouldn't flag.

"My work as a Candy Striper has really influenced me to become a nurse."

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Please have at least 2 people read your essay to check for major errors. Bonus if you use people who don't have a massively vested interest in your college education.

Make sure your essay can stand alone.

Avoid saying something along the lines of, "As I stated earlier in my application..." Please re-write the topic at the top of the essay so we can quickly identify what you're writing about.

Be careful with humor.

It can be tough to pull off in writing. And remember – you don't necessarily know your audience. Your essay will be read by a number of different people from a wide array of ages and backgrounds.

What we're looking for

Tell us what is unique about you.

Why would you stand out among our 30,000+ applicants? Is there something different about your personal experiences? Your response should provide us with an opportunity to get to know you on a more personal level, beyond your GPA, test scores, and curriculum.

Use recent examples.

It's always best to focus on issues that occurred while you were in high school, since we're only reviewing your high school performance when determining if you'll be admitted. If something happened when you were younger that has significantly affected you, talk about it, but then put the focus on how this event has affected you in recent years.

Watch your tone.

There's a big difference in focusing your essay on "U of M needs me as a student because..." versus "please please please admit me!"

Don't make excuses.

If you've had a poor or inconsistent grade performance due to unusual or stressful circumstances, feel free to share that information with us; it can be useful. But don't strain credibility by making up false excuses. Be honest – we'll respect that.

Be truthful, but make sure you're comfortable with your potential audience.

Students often feel compelled to share extremely personal and even traumatic experiences in their responses – health issues, death of a family member, abuse, etc. We will absolutely keep your information confidential; however, if you decide to reveal something deeply personal, be aware that a number of people will potentially be reading your essay.

Tell us why we're great.

Talk about campus programs you've attended. Tell us why you're a great fit for Michigan. Remember that athletics can be a reason, but should not be the only reason you want to come to Ann Arbor!



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Tips for a Great College Essay

Why write an essay?

The purpose of the essay is to convince admission officers whom you've never met, in less than ten minutes, that you would be a good match for their colleges.

At the most basic level, it allows admission officers to evaluate your communication and writing skills. In addition, the essay allows admission officers to discover more about you as a person – a side of you not shown by statistics like grades and SATs. The essay gives information about your history, attitudes, interests and creativity; it gives a sense of your values and goals. What admission officers are doing is creating a community...looking to see how you would fit in that community, what would you bring to that community and what sets you apart.

How the essay is evaluated

- Is your writing mechanically sound? Is your writing style comfortable? Can you write a good sentence? Can you write a good paragraph? Do you address the question asked?
- Can you form a thesis? Can you discuss a theme? Is your argument logical? Can you get in and out of the essay with some finesse?
- Do you write with style, nuance and creativity? Do you write with a distinctive voice?

Choosing a topic

Choose the essay topic that appeals to *you* most. The topic is less important than your delivery. Remember: there is no right or wrong answer. The college just wants to know who you are and how your mind works.

Bad essay topics - there are bad essays, not bad topics; but be careful about the following:

- Winning or losing the big game.
- Death of a pet.
- Friendship problems.
- Religious or philosophical epiphanies.
- Telling troubles to a journal.
- Anything that suggests that you don't see the world beyond high school.
- Simple solutions to world problems.
- Essays in poor taste.
- Parent-bashing.
- Cynicism almost never plays well.
- Remember, be sure to answer the question!

The first draft

- Narrow your topic and try to be as specific as possible.
- Brainstorm – scribble down everything you can think of about your chosen topic. Pick out the good stuff and work it into a brief outline.
- Write a rough draft. Read it. Read it again - out loud.
- Ask yourself: Have I focused on the topic? Have I answered the question? Is it specific and detailed? Have I written in my own voice?

Polishing the essay

- Eliminate the first sentence (or two)...that allows the essay to “start fast.” A good opening sentence will hook the reader. If *you’re* bored, the reader will be bored.
- Add details to make it richer and more interesting.
- Be revealing...let us know things about you, but don’t be confessional.
- Be careful with sentimentality...use it sparingly.
- Beware of trying to impress us with what you think we want to hear.
- Don’t try to “prove” your intelligence by choosing a topic you think makes you sound smart. Avoid sophisticated words when simpler ones will suffice.
- Don’t be afraid to use your imagination. Don’t be afraid to be unconventional. But, don’t be weird just for the sake of being weird.
- Be concise. Ask yourself: “Have I avoided repetitiveness? Did I make my points directly and without a lot of unnecessary padding?”
- Show; don’t tell. Don’t just list what you have done – detail it with action words. Make your writing come alive to the reader. Use quotations wisely – to move the story along or prove a point.
- Start early!
- Ask a teacher, parent or friend to read your second draft. Ask them: “Is it interesting from the word go? Does it sound like me? Was it fun to read?” Listen to what they have to say, but don’t let someone else rewrite the essay for you.
- Read what the application says about essay length, but don’t just write to fill space.

Navigational hazards

The little details aren’t the most important part of the essay, but you *are* trying to make a good impression. You don’t want the admission committee to think you’re a sloppy, careless writer.

- *Always proofread* before producing the final draft. If you are sick and tired of the essay, let someone else proof it. Check for spelling errors. Spellcheck won’t catch everything!
- Check your word choice by reading out loud. What looks good on paper may sound awkward or, in fact, say nothing.
- Make sure that if you are including the name of the college in the essay, it’s the correct school. *Wesleyan* doesn’t want to know you’ve always wanted to go to *Smith*.
- If you are going to take risks (which is OK), be sure you know your subject matter and feel comfortable with that style of writing. For instance, poetry is often risky.
- Don’t try to inject humor if you’re not funny. Be careful even if you *are* funny...it often doesn’t translate in writing.
- Remember: a college essay is not a research paper. In fact, most often students are asked to evaluate a significant experience or achievement that has special meaning. That’s a very personal question.

The biggest mistake of all

- Don’t plagiarize: admission officers have read all the books and seen all the websites.

The good news

- Don’t stress too much – write what you feel, do it well... and we’ll like you!